Jagannatha Mishra

Джаганнатха Мишра · @jagannatha-mishra

A Family from Shrihatta

Jagannatha Mishra's forebears lived in Shrihatta (Sylhet), in eastern Bengal. The “Prema-vilasa” (ch. 24) preserves their genealogy. Madhu Mishra had four sons — Upendra, Rangada,[1] Kirtida and Kirtivasa. Upendra Mishra and his wife Kalavati[2] had seven sons: Kamsari, Paramananda, Padmanabha, Sarveshvara, Jagannatha, Janardana and Trailokyanatha. Jagannatha was the fifth; he was born in the village of Dhaka-dakshina. Upendra himself is identified by the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (35) as the cowherd Parjanya, Krishna's grandfather in Vraja.

From Shrihatta Jagannatha moved to the bank of the Ganga, to Navadvipa, and built his house in Mayapur — on the very spot where the Lord would later appear. Krishnadasa Kaviraja describes him thus:

“The best of the brothers, Sri Jagannatha Mishra, was also known as Purandara. Like Krishna's fathers — Vasudeva and Nanda Maharaja — he was a reservoir of every virtue.” (CC, Adi 13.59)

“His wife, Srimati Shachidevi, was a chaste woman, wholly devoted to her husband. Her father was Nilambara Chakravarti.” (CC, Adi 13.60)

The title “Purandara” is one of the epithets of Indra, king of the gods.

Neighbours and Friends

Around Mishra's house settled people who were destined to become the Lord's companions. Even before His appearance Srivasa built his home close by on the bank of the Ganga. He and his brothers were Jagannatha's close friends; tradition says they understood in advance that Krishna would come to this very house. Srivasa visited Mishra so often that he seemed to be his shadow, and his wife Malini became Shachi's friend. Nearby also lived Madhava Mishra and Ratnavati, the parents of Gadadhara Pandita.

Later Jagadisha Pandita came from Assam with his wife Duhkhini and his brother Hiranya[3] and also settled next door. Jagadisha became one of Jagannatha's closest friends. He and Hiranya knew that Hari Himself had been born as their neighbour's son.

The Children and the Lord's Appearance

For a long time grief weighed upon the family: Shachi and Jagannatha had eight daughters, and not one survived.[4] Then Jagannatha performed a special rite praying for a son, and soon Vishvarupa was born — a manifestation of Baladeva, the Sankarshana of the spiritual world, who is also called Nityananda's second self. By the day of Mahaprabhu's appearance He was the only one of the children left in the house.

Before He comes, the Lord sends to the earth those whom He will honour as His elders:

“Before descending to the earth, Krishna sends here many of His devotees, who take the roles of His respected forefathers, teachers and elders.” (CC, Adi 3.92)

“Thus first His venerable parents and teachers take birth on the earth.” (CC, Adi 3.93)

“Madhavendra Puri, Ishvara Puri, Srimati Shachimata and Jagannatha Mishra appeared together with Advaita Acharya.” (CC, Adi 3.94)

Krishnadasa Kaviraja says the same in another place:

“First He sent to the earth all His intimates and elders. I shall name them briefly — to describe them all in detail is simply impossible.” (CC, Adi 13.53)

“Sri Shachidevi and Jagannatha Mishra, Sri Madhavendra Puri, Keshava Bharati, Ishvara Puri, Advaita Acharya, Srivasa Pandita, Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi and Thakura Haridasa.” (CC, Adi 13.54–55)

Lochana Dasa, in the “Chaitanya-mangala,” tells how Krishna, in Dvaraka, revealed to Narada that He would appear in Navadvipa in a golden form, with all His associates, as the son of Shachi and Jagannatha Mishra.

When Shachi was carrying the Lord, in the sixth month Advaita Acharya came to the house. He bowed to the child in her womb and walked around her, and when the astonished couple asked what this homage meant, he only answered that in time they would know. When the time drew near, Jagannatha, seeing the signs of the coming birth, sent word to Shantipur. On hearing it, Advaita bathed in the Ganga with Haridasa, sang and danced for a long time, and then sent His wife Sita to Mayapur.

The Lord appeared on the full-moon day of the month of Phalguna in 1486 (1407 of the Shaka era), at sunset, during a lunar eclipse. The townspeople were calling “Hari!” and “Krishna!”, the women raised the joyful ulu cry, and the music of the gods sounded from the heavens. So in Sri Mayapur the Lord accepted Jagannatha and Shachi as His father and mother. When they saw their son's face, both forgot themselves in joy. Jagannatha himself and all the people of Nadia who came to see the child marvelled at His beauty: a lion's neck, arms like an elephant's trunk, a broad chest, and on His feet the marks of Vishnu. “This is no ordinary child,” people said. Day and night crowds came to Mishra's house, and it became like Vaikuntha; Narahari Sarakara, too, sings of this in one of his songs.

The child's maternal grandfather, Nilambara Chakravarti, a master of the science of the stars, cast His horoscope and announced that the boy would be a king of kings and would hold every virtue in Himself — more than that, He was Narayana Himself. Jagannatha and the whole household were plunged in an ocean of happiness. According to one account, a realised soul in the guise of a brahmana was present when the horoscope was cast. He foretold that through this child the world would receive love for Krishna in its highest, most intimate rasa, such as no one had ever given before. “How fortunate I am to have cast the Lord's horoscope!” he said, and named the baby Vishvambhara. He also foresaw the future sannyasa but kept silent, so that the sad news would not cloud the parents' joy.[5]

Shachi and the other women called the boy Nimai[6] — after the bitter neem tree, which, it is said, witches and evil spirits dare not approach. In this way they wished Him a long life. Later, on taking sannyasa, He received the name Sri Krishna Chaitanya; He is also called Vishvambhara, Navadvipa-chandra, Gaurahari, Gauranga and Mahaprabhu.

Sita Thakurani, Advaita's wife, soon arrived in a palanquin, with maidservants and a wealth of gifts. On the day mother and child first came out of the birth chamber, she gave them presents and honoured Jagannatha, and the couple in turn honoured her. Afterwards she often came from Shantipur and taught the young parents how to care for the child. On His birthday Shachi and Jagannatha gave her the honour of being the first to offer the boy new clothes. Srivasa and his wife also came with gifts: they brought oil, bananas and fruits and performed the auspicious rites.

On the day after Phalguni-purnima, on Krishna-pratipada, Vaishnavas still keep the Anandotsava of Jagannatha Mishra, remembering the festival of joy he held to celebrate his son's birth. The days of Gaura's and Nityananda's appearance are themselves holy:

“Gaurachandra appeared on the night of the full moon of the month of Phalguna, and Lord Nityananda appeared in the month of Magha on the thirteenth day of the waxing moon.” (CB, Adi 3.45)

Whoever honours these days with fasting and festival has the bonds of ignorance cut and the desire to serve Krishna awakened.

Nimai's Childhood

Only the holy names could console the crying baby: as soon as the adults began to sing, He fell silent. At four months He would scatter household things about, but on catching sight of His mother He would lie down and cry. Shachi never thought to blame Him: she supposed it was an evil spirit that her protective prayers had driven off. Every morning the neighbour women gathered round the boy and sang the names of Hari, while He danced and rolled in the dust. The sweets and bananas that friends and strangers alike gave Him He handed out to the singers as prasada.

When the time came to test the child's inclinations, Jagannatha laid before Him rice, puffed rice, gold, silver and a manuscript of the “Srimad-Bhagavatam.” The boy reached past everything straight for the book, and the learned guests foretold that He would be a great pandita. Some biographies place this at the name-giving ceremony, others at the annaprashana, the first feeding of rice; the latter add that He pressed the book to His chest, as if foreshadowing His future preaching.[7] At the annaprashana, one biography says, He took neither grain, nor silver, nor gold, the things that would suit a vaishya, nor puffed rice, which a brahmana fond of food would snatch, but out of the many scriptures that follow the Veda He chose the “Bhagavatam” alone. The meaning of this pastime is plain: the highest authority in spiritual matters is the “Bhagavatam.” According to the “Chaitanya-mangala,” the annaprashana was held when He was six months old, and only afterwards was He named.

Vishvambhara learned to walk holding His father's finger with His tiny hand. When He had begun to crawl, He once saw a snake in the courtyard — it was Shesha. The golden Narayana played with him and lay down on his coils. Jagannatha and the whole household cried out and wept in terror, and the snake slid away. Shachi and Jagannatha had seen their son's wondrous form, and in their hearts they no longer doubted that He was the Lord Himself. But, fearing for the child, the parents told no one of His wonders, and even the devotees of Navadvipa did not yet know for certain Who had been born in Mishra's house.

As He grew, Nimai would go into the neighbours' houses for milk and rice, and if He found nothing to eat He would break their pots. His mischief delights devotees to this day. Once, as He was playing by the gate, two thieves coveted His ornaments, put Him on their shoulders and carried Him off. But the Lord bewildered them, and without noticing it they came back to Mishra's house and fled in fear. Jagannatha, who had been searching everywhere, pressed his son to his heart: it seemed to him that his own life had been given back.

Another time the father asked Nimai to bring a book from the house. While the boy ran to fetch it, the parents heard a wonderful jingling of ankle bells, and then saw on the floor small footprints bearing the marks of the flag, the thunderbolt, the elephant goad and the banner. Parental love would not let them believe these were their son's footprints. They decided that their household Deity, the Damodara shalagrama, was walking about the house, and they bathed Him, worshipped Him and made Him an offering.[8] Thus again and again their love for the child hid from them Who He was.[9]

The Pilgrim with Bala-Gopala

Once a pilgrim brahmana who worshipped Bala-Gopala — Krishna as a child — passed through Navadvipa. Jagannatha received him with honour and gave him a place for his worship and everything needed for cooking. But no sooner had the guest sat down to offer the food to his Deity in meditation than Nimai appeared and began to eat. The brahmana cried out. Jagannatha, deeply upset, was about to punish his son, but the guest held him back.

The brahmana did not want to cook again, yet his host prevailed upon him and this time took Nimai to a neighbour's house. It all happened again: the moment the pilgrim began his offering, Gaura-Gopala was there. “Everything is ruined!” the guest lamented, and when Jagannatha again wanted to punish the boy, he said: “He is only a child and understands nothing. It is not His fault — it seems I am not meant to eat today.”

The third time it was the elder brother, Vishvarupa, who persuaded the guest. It was already long past midnight; Nimai was asleep (it was the sleep of yoga, yoga-nidra), and the brahmana waited until the whole house was sleeping. Yet even now Gaura-Gopala came to the offering — and showed the guest an eight-armed form: in four hands the conch, disc, club and lotus of Narayana, in one a lump of butter, from which He took and ate with another, and with two He played the flute. The pilgrim fainted. On coming to, he heard: “Tell no one of this. You have been My servant for many lives; the same thing happened in Nanda's house in Gokula.” From then on the brahmana wandered no more and came every day to Mishra's house to see his Lord.[10]

Schooling

The rites of childhood — the piercing of the ears, the first tonsure and the initiation into letters — Jagannatha performed himself. In three days the boy learned the whole alphabet and began to read and write the names of Krishna. On the day his son began school, the father was very happy. That night a brahmana appeared to him in a dream and said: “Your son is Bhagavan Himself. Who can teach the Lord or punish Him?” Mishra understood this in the dream, but on waking he gave himself up again to parental love and forgot it.

Sometimes Nimai would demand birds, the moon or the stars from His parents and cry if He did not get them; only the holy names would quiet Him. One Ekadashi even they did not help. At last the boy confessed that He wanted to taste what had been offered to Vishnu that day in the house of the brahmanas Jagadisha and Hiranya. Jagannatha was astonished: how could a child know about the offering? Besides, was it fitting for his son to eat rice on Ekadashi? Still, he went to his friends and told them of the request. Jagadisha understood at once that it was Gopala Himself, in the form of Nimai, who was hungry, and without hesitation gave Him the whole offering. As soon as the boy received the prasada His tears dried, and He joyfully began to eat.

“Other branches are Jagadisha Pandita and Hiranya Mahashaya, to whom Sri Chaitanya showed His greatest mercy in His childhood.” (CC, Adi 10.70)

“In their houses Sri Chaitanya asked for the food offered to Vishnu on the day of Ekadashi, and ate it Himself.” (CC, Adi 10.71)

For Krishna the son of Nanda, Gaurasundara the son of Jagannatha Mishra, and Lord Jagannatha are one and the same Supreme Lord.

The men complained of Nimai's pranks to His father, the girls and women to Shachi. Jagannatha would grow angry and go to punish his son, but would find Him so calm and innocent that he could only marvel. “Who is this child?” the parents wondered. “Has Nandanandana Himself been secretly born to us?” To treat the Lord as a son is granted only to His eternal associate.

Vishvarupa Leaves Home

From childhood Vishvarupa was indifferent to worldly things. He studied with Advaita Acharya and understood that all the scriptures come down to one thing — service to Krishna. When He was twelve and His parents began to speak of marriage, He left home and took sannyasa with the name Shankararanya. Shachi and Jagannatha were struck down by separation from their firstborn; little

Gaurasundara grieved too. Advaita Acharya and Sita Thakurani consoled them and helped to bring up Nimai.

Now the father feared that learning would turn the younger son away from the family as well. “Better he stay an unlettered boy at home than become a pandita and leave,” he decided, and stopped his son's lessons.[11] Nimai answered with fresh mischief. Once He sat down on a heap of discarded pots in which food had been cooked for Vishnu. Shachi called Him away, but He answered like the sage Dattatreya: an unlettered boy cannot tell pure from impure; pots in which food was cooked for Vishnu cannot be defiled; and where I am there can be no impurity; talk of purity drawn from the karma-kanda is only the invention of those who know nothing but the material world. Seeing that her son would not move, Shachi dragged Him away by force, bathed Him and bathed herself. Then she and the neighbours came to Jagannatha and begged him to let the boy return to His studies, and the father gave way.

The Last Years

After the upanayana — the sacred-thread ceremony — Nimai, like Vamana, went round the houses with a begging bowl. Then, when Nimai Himself wished to study under Gangadasa Pandita, Jagannatha took Him there — to him who in Krishna's pastimes had been His teacher Sandipani Muni. Gangadasa was delighted to have such a pupil, though the boy plagued him and His fellow students with tricky questions of logic, to everyone's amazement.

The father rejoiced at his son's disciplined life: a bath in the Ganga every day, worship of Vishnu according to all the rules, water for the tulasi, prasada — and then study in solitude. Mishra prayed to Krishna for his son's welfare, yet fear would not leave him: what if his son grasped the emptiness of samsara and went away? One night he dreamed of Mahaprabhu as a sannyasi: surrounded by devotees, He was singing, dancing, laughing and weeping in sankirtana. From then on Mishra was sure that Nimai would leave home, and Shachi, however much she argued that their son was too absorbed in His studies, could not dissuade him. Much later, admonishing his pupil, Gangadasa would tell Him:

“Your maternal grandfather is Nilambara Chakravarti, and Your father is Jagannatha Mishra Purandara. In the families of Your father and mother there has never been an ignorant man.” (CB, Madhya 1.273–274)

Departure from the World

Jagannatha Mishra did not see his son's sannyasa: he left this world before it. This happened soon after the upanayana, when Nimai had become wholly absorbed in study; according to the “Chaitanya-mangala,” Mishra fell ill and entered the unseen, eternal pastimes of the Lord.[12] As Ramachandra wept at parting from His devotee Dasharatha, so Gaurasundara wept much when His devotee, His father, departed; but He held firm in order to console His mother. He explained to Shachi how fleeting a man's life in this world is, and revealed other truths to her; after this He took up His studies in earnest.

To perform the shraddha for His father the Lord went to Gaya. There He met Ishvara Puri and, as Vrindavana Dasa Thakura relates (CB, Adi 17.50–52), told him that His journey to Gaya had reached its goal the moment He saw his feet: an offering to the ancestors at a holy place delivers only those to whom it is offered, but merely to see Ishvara Puri is enough for millions of ancestors to be delivered at once.

The care of the widow's household was taken up by Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna. He lived next door to Mishra (today Sri Chaitanya Math of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati stands on that spot) and with his wife constantly came to his house and helped to run it.[13] Soon Shachi married her son to Lakshmipriya,

the daughter of Vallabhacharya. The matchmaker Vanamali Acharya told the bride's father: “Vishvambhara, the son of Jagannatha Mishra, is a great scholar and an ocean of every virtue.”

Mishra's House

Ishana Thakura served in the house as Jagannatha's faithful servant. Much help came to Mishra also from Hiranya and Govardhana Majumdar of Saptagrama, who honoured Nilambara Chakravarti as their elder brother. Sannyasis, too, remembered the hospitality of this home. Once Madhavendra Puri had come here with his disciple Sri Ranga Puri, and Shachi had served them a curry of banana flowers. Years later, in Pandharpur, Ranga Puri met Mahaprabhu, learned that He came from Navadvipa, and recalled:

“They had then taken their meal in the house of Jagannatha Mishra, and he still remembered the indescribable taste of the banana-flower curry.” (CC, Madhya 9.296)

“Jagannatha Mishra's wife remained in his memory as a most devoted and chaste woman. She showed them such care, as if she were the mother of the whole universe.” (CC, Madhya 9.297)

“One of her worthy sons took sannyasa while still young, receiving the name Shankararanya.” (CC, Madhya 9.299)

“Sri Ranga Puri told Sri Chaitanya that Shankararanya had attained perfection and left this world right in this holy place, Pandarpur.” (CC, Madhya 9.300)

“Sri Chaitanya said: ‘Before taking sannyasa Shankararanya was My brother, and Jagannatha Mishra My father.’” (CC, Madhya 9.301)[14]

Vishvarupa left His body at Pandharpur (Sholapur district, Maharashtra) in 1509 (1431 Shaka).

The courtyard of Shachi, where the infant Vishvambhara danced, was sung of by Vasu Ghosha in a pada. After the Lord's departure the house became a place of pilgrimage. Narottama Dasa Thakura came to its threshold and fell at the door in tears, and inside he met Shuklambara Brahmachari. Shyamananda (then still Duhkhi Krishnadasa) asked the people of Navadvipa where the old house of Jagannatha Mishra was, and found there the aged Ishana. Later Ramachandra Kaviraja came as well and received the blessings of the same Ishana.

When the Lord's birthplace was rediscovered at the end of the nineteenth century, Jagannatha Dasa Babaji proposed that Deities of Jagannatha and Shachi be installed there in one temple, and Mahaprabhu with Lakshmipriya and Vishnupriya in another. And on 13 June 1934,[15] while the foundations of the new temple at the Yogapitha were being dug, a four-armed Deity of Vishnu — Adhokshaja — was taken from the earth. It was He whom Jagannatha Mishra had worshipped in his home.

The Father of the Lord

Who, then, was this brahmana from Shrihatta? Krishnadasa Kaviraja answers:

“The king of Vraja, Nanda Maharaja, has now become the father of Sri Chaitanya, and Yashoda, the queen of Vraja, has become His mother, Sri Shachidevi.” (CC, Adi 17.294)

“Now the son of Nanda Maharaja is Sri Chaitanya, and Baladeva is Sri Chaitanya's brother, Nityananda.” (CC, Adi 17.295)

Kavi Karnapura says the same:

“Yashoda and the king of Vraja, Nanda, who once in Vrindavana were mines of the rasa of love, became Shachi and Jagannatha Purandara — of this there is no doubt. Into them also entered the divine Aditi and Kashyapa, Sri Kaushalya and Dasharatha, and Sri Prishni and her husband.” (GGD 37–38)

Thus in the Lord's father were united all who in earlier descents had been the father of God: Kashyapa, Dasharatha, Sutapa and Vasudeva.[16]

Jagannatha and Shachi are eternal, ever-free associates of Krishna. Their hearts and bodies are made of pure goodness, shuddha-sattva, which is also called “vasudeva”: in it Krishna manifests Himself, and therefore He is called Vasudeva. This brahmana couple is the chief shelter of transcendental parental love. Vrindavana Dasa Thakura says of Jagannatha:

“He was magnanimous and possessed all the noble qualities of a brahmana. No one could compare with him.” (CB, Adi 2.137)

And Vaishnavas glorify the Lord as Vishvambhara — the son of Jagannatha Mishra and Shachidevi, ever beloved of His devotees.

1. In another reading, Rangana.

2. In the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (36) Krishna's grandmother Mahamanya, born as Upendra's wife, is called Kamalavati.

3. According to one biography, Jagadisha was accompanied by his younger brother Mahesha.

4. Some biographies specify that the girls died at birth, others say only that they were born and departed. Krishnadasa Kaviraja writes that they died immediately after birth (CC, Adi 13.72), and that Jagannatha then began to worship Vishnu, praying for a son (CC, Adi 13.73).

5. According to some biographies, the name Vishvambhara was given at the name-giving ceremony by Nilambara Chakravarti and other learned men; according to others, by this brahmana when the horoscope was cast; according to a third, by the brahmanas, because the child delighted the whole world.

6. According to other biographies, the name Nimai was given by Sita Thakurani; so too Krishnadasa Kaviraja: having blessed the infant, she named Him Nimai to protect Him from witches and evil spirits (CC, Adi 13.117).

7. According to some biographies, the test took place at the name-giving ceremony; according to others, at the annaprashana.

8. In one biography this story comes before the episode of the snake, in another after it.

9. This is no worldly ignorance. The Lord and His eternal associates are not subject to maya: knowledge of His majesty is hidden from the parents by yogamaya — the Lord's internal potency, which serves His lila — so that nothing should stand in the way of their pure parental love (vatsalya). Hence the father's anger and his wish to punish his son are also part of the lila: in this way the Lord relishes the love of His eternal associates, who see in Him not God but their own child.

10. According to some biographies, the brahmana stayed in Navadvipa for good and came to Nimai's house every evening; according to others, he begged his food elsewhere but came to Mishra's house every day.

11. According to one account, both parents together stopped the lessons and themselves sent their son back to school on hearing Him speak in the mood of Dattatreya; according to another, the decision was the father's, and he gave way to the entreaties of Shachi and the neighbours.

12. The biographies describe the time of his departure differently: soon after the upanayana; after the upanayana, from illness; shortly before the Lord's pilgrimage to Gaya. One of them says that he entered the eternal pastimes (nitya-lila).

13. The biographies differ on the time: according to one, Chandrashekhara and his wife helped the family even before the Lord's appearance; according to another, after it, coming to see the Child and to care for Him.

14. According to one biography, the Lord named Jagannatha Mishra and Shachi as His father and mother; Krishnadasa Kaviraja and another biography name only the father.

15. The year is clear from the course of the narrative: these were the excavations during the building of the temple by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati.

16. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (39) adds that, in the view of some, Devaki and Vasudeva also entered them. Some biographies say that the Lord's former parents “entered” Jagannatha and Shachi, others that they are the same persons, known by different names in different pastimes (though they too quote the same verse about “entering”).